Use your own AI

For most of the AI era so far, using artificial intelligence has meant going somewhere else. Open a browser. Sign into a service. Type a prompt. Upload a file. Wait for a distant data centre to do the thinking. It has been convenient, often astonishingly so, but it has also trained us to think of AI as something we rent access to rather than something our own computers can run.

That assumption is now breaking.

By 2026, the hardware in ordinary PCs has become much more capable, model developers have become better at shrinking and optimising AI, and the open-model ecosystem has exploded. Hugging Face hosts more than 2 million models, alongside 1.5 million datasets and 1.5 million AI apps called Spaces. Google says its Gemma 4 family alone has crossed 150 million downloads. OpenAI's gpt-oss-20b can run within roughly 16GB of memory. These are not obscure research experiments anymore. They are increasingly practical software that you can download, store and run yourself.

The PC market is moving in the same direction. IDC says India shipped 4.4 million traditional PCs in the first quarter of 2026, up 31.1 percent year-on-year. AI notebook shipments rose 96.1 percent over the same period, while premium notebooks above US$1,000 grew 70.1 percent. Globally, IDC expects roughly 50 million generative-AI PCs to ship during 2026, accounting for close to one-fifth of all PC shipments.

But running your own AI does not necessarily require buying one of those shiny new "AI PCs".

That is one of the most useful ideas to understand. A recent laptop or desktop may already be capable of running competent models. A powerful gaming PC can go considerably further. Apple Silicon systems can exploit unified memory. Older machines may still handle small, heavily quantised models. The question is not simply, "Does my PC have an NPU?" It is: how much memory do I have, what processor or GPU is available, how large is the model, and how has that model been packaged?

And why bother?

Privacy is one reason. When a model runs locally, your prompt does not inherently need to leave your computer. LM Studio, for example, says downloaded models, chat histories and locally processed documents can remain entirely on-device, and the program can continue chatting with models or documents without an internet connection. That opens possibilities for confidential notes, unpublished work, personal documents, code and material that you might be reluctant to send to a remote service.

Control is another. Cloud AI changes whenever its provider changes it. Models appear, disappear, acquire limits, lose features or move behind different subscription tiers. A locally stored model is yours to keep running in the version you downloaded. You can select a tiny, fast model for everyday questions, a larger one when quality matters, a coding specialist when you are programming, or an Indian-language model when English is not the job.

There are trade-offs. Local models consume storage, RAM, electricity and sometimes patience. The biggest cloud systems will still outperform your laptop on many difficult tasks. Large context windows require more memory. A model that technically loads may run painfully slowly. And "local" does not magically mean safe: you still need to think about where a model came from, what licence governs it, and what software you install around it.

That is precisely what makes this moment interesting.

For the first time, choosing an AI model is beginning to resemble choosing software for your PC. There are lightweight choices, heavyweight choices, specialists, generalists, free downloads, licence restrictions, hardware requirements and performance compromises. You can experiment. You can benchmark. You can decide that one model is brilliant at coding but terrible at Hinglish, while another is slower but better at summarising long documents.

Most importantly, you can switch the Wi-Fi off and the AI can keep talking.

This Fast Track is about getting you to that point. Not theoretically, and not through a tour of academic jargon, but by helping you understand what is available, what your machine can realistically handle, how to choose wisely, and how to turn your PC into a private, useful AI workstation.

The cloud is not going away. But AI no longer has to live there on everyday hardware.